An attempt at popularising Kalamkari

MADRAS.

"As a craft it needs neither too much of skill nor finance to keep an individual in business. Yet Kalamkari is almost becoming extinct", regrets Mrs. Shakuntala Ramani, Chairman of Kalakshetra's Craft Education and Research Centre.

About five years ago the Crafts Council of India chose Kalakshetra to revitalise this art—hand printing on fabrics using vegetable dyes—in these parts and take up a combined project of training women and setting up a production unit.

After overcoming a bit of a crisis within two years when the Crafts Council sponsorship came to an end, the Kalamkari Centre continues to be at the crossroads even now, when the second phase of assistance, this time by State Bank of India is drawing to an end.

Kalamkari is so simple and a person needs only patience and time, in addition to inclination, says Mrs. Ramani. "Vegetable dyes themselves are becoming a rarity these days and we have attempted not only to keep them alive, but innovate within our limitations."

With the bank's assistance under the 'Innovative banking' scheme and an R and D effort, the Centre has diversified its dyes and the printing blocks. Fullfledged tables for printing have replaced makeshift arrangements. A whole saree length is now pinned atop the table and the women proceed meticulously to print the chosen design.

The craft gets its name from 'kalam' (a sharp instrument resembling a pen) and 'kari' (meaning craft). Though practised in several centres, the art lives in Andhra Pradesh—especially in places like Srikalahasti and Machilipatnam. At Kalakshetra, they are trying to combine the two styles.

The basic black dye is made by soaking iron pieces in a solution of jaggery and water and allowing it to ferment in a mud pot for about 20 days. The mordant widely used for fixing of other vegetable colours is alum, which is both cheap and easily available. The dyes used in kalamkari are essentially derived from roots and herbs. Myrobalam *(Kadukka)* forms an essential ingredient.

Mrs. Shakuntala says that as of now the colours available by the use of vegetable dyes here are red, brown, yellow, green and some variations of them. A project to develop indigo and thereby get varieties of blue is on the anvil.

Now that the State Bank assistance peters to an end, the Centre plans to make itself self-sufficient. Only two batches of women, mostly from the villages around Thiruvanmiyur, have completed their training. Four of them have joined the production unit and are also training the new entrants. Besides continuing the training programme, the Centre hopes to stabilise its production, concentrate on sales and keep the unit going. With the help of the Crafts Council, contacts have been established with sales outlets in Bombay and other places for firm and continuing orders.

Because of the 'hand-to-mouth' existance till now, the Centre has not been able to pay the women very well. But it is basicaily a welfare project and the women do not seem to mind the low wages.

In another attempt to popularise the kalamkari products—ranging from sarees and bedsheets to wall hangings and table mats—the Crafts Council has arranged for an exhibition from February 4 to 9 at the Centre. Mrs. Rukmini Devi will inaugurate the exhibition.—Our Staff Reporter.



A display of Kalamkari sarees, bedspreads, table cloth, cushion covers etc., produced by the Kalakshetra Craft Education and Research Centre.

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